ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

Scholarships, Grants and Financial Aid: Apply Without Wasting Money

Find legitimate opportunities, prepare documents early and write a strong application

MONEY & CAREER

Money & Career

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Scholarship information is scattered and often surrounded by fraud. This pack explains where legitimate opportunities are announced, how to prepare a reusable document pack, how to write a personal statement that does not sound generic, and how to recognise fake portals.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Identify credible sources of scholarship and grant information.
- Prepare a reusable application document pack.
- Write a specific personal statement and request references properly.
- Recognise and avoid scholarship scams.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Where legitimate opportunities live

Reliable information comes from institutions, not from forwarded messages.

- University scholarship offices, faculty notice boards and official websites.
- Federal and state scholarship boards, and their verified portals.
- Corporate foundations and professional bodies in Nigeria.
- Embassy and international development programmes.
- Departmental and alumni awards, which are often under-applied for.
- Verify every opportunity on an official domain before submitting anything.

Prepare once, apply many times

Most applications ask for the same material. Build a pack.

- Academic transcripts or results, admission letter and student ID.
- A current CV of one page.
- A personal statement of 500 to 800 words that you can adapt.
- Two academic references with up-to-date contact details.
- Passport photographs in the required specification.
- Certificates and evidence of leadership or volunteering.

> **Legitimate schemes do not ask for payment**
> Application fees and 'processing charges' from unknown portals are a warning sign. Confirm with the institution before paying anything.

Write it specifically

Reviewers read many similar statements. Specificity is your advantage.

1. Open with a concrete moment that explains your direction, not a quotation.
2. State your course and the problem you want to work on.
3. Give evidence: results, projects, responsibilities, measurable outcomes.
4. Explain why this specific scheme, not any scholarship.
5. Describe what you will do afterwards in concrete terms.
6. Edit for length, clarity and one consistent tense.

How funding is actually decided

Scholarship panels are not looking for the most deserving person in the abstract; they are looking for evidence against stated criteria. Read the eligibility rules first and check whether you meet every one. A brilliant application to a fund you are not eligible for is wasted effort.

Most awards weigh three things: academic record, financial need, and the applicant's capacity to use the opportunity. Application quality matters because panels read hundreds of similar statements; specificity is what makes one memorable.

Timing decides more outcomes than talent. Applications have fixed windows, transcripts take weeks, and referees need notice. Work backwards from the deadline by at least six weeks.

The documents and the statement

Prepare a master file: academic transcripts, certificates, identification, admission letter, passport photographs, a curriculum vitae, and a bank verification number where required. Keep scanned copies at a consistent resolution and named clearly. Most missed deadlines are document problems, not merit problems.

The personal statement should answer three questions: what you are studying and why, what you have done that shows commitment, and what you will do with the support. Avoid generic claims about passion. One specific anecdote - a project, a role, a problem you solved - is worth a paragraph of adjectives.

Choose referees who know your work and give them your CV, the award criteria, and the deadline. A referee who is told nothing writes a letter that could be about anyone.

> **Never pay to apply**
> Legitimate scholarships do not charge application or processing fees. Any request for payment is fraud, however official the website looks.

Where to look and how to avoid fraud

Sources: your department and faculty notice boards, the university scholarship office, state government education secretariats, professional bodies, religious organisations, corporate foundations, and the official websites of the institutions you are applying to. The most reliable information is usually the least advertised.

Verify every opportunity against an official domain or a phone number you found yourself. Treat any offer that arrives unsolicited, demands urgency, or asks for bank details by message as fraud until proven otherwise.

Keep a tracker: award name, deadline, documents required, status. Applying to six awards with a tracker beats applying to twenty in a panic, because you will actually meet the deadlines.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Building a master document file

You want to be ready for any award that opens.

1. Scan transcripts, certificates, admission letter and identification at 300 dpi.
2. Name each file clearly with type and date.
3. Write a one-page CV with education, roles, skills and two referees.
4. Draft a 500-word statement you can adapt to different criteria.
5. Store everything in one folder and one cloud location.
6. Review the file each semester and update it.

> **What to carry forward**
> A prepared file turns a two-week scramble into a two-hour application.

2. Assessing an award for eligibility

A scholarship requires a minimum CGPA of 3.5, a state of origin, and full-time enrolment.

1. Check each criterion honestly against your record.
2. If you meet all three, note the deadline and required documents.
3. If you do not, decide whether another award fits better.
4. Do not apply hoping the rules will be waived.
5. Record the decision in your tracker so you do not revisit it later.
6. Share the opportunity with a classmate who is eligible.

> **What to carry forward**
> Eligibility first. Effort spent on ineligible applications is effort not spent on eligible ones.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. What do scholarship panels typically assess, and how should an applicant respond?

15 marks

1. Academic record - provide transcripts and evidence of performance.
2. Financial need - follow the stated documentation exactly.
3. Capacity to use the opportunity - show specific plans and past commitment.
4. Application quality - be specific rather than generic.

Q2. How can a student identify and avoid fraudulent scholarship offers?

10 marks

1. Legitimate funds never charge processing fees.
2. Verify through an official domain or independently found phone number.
3. Treat urgency and unsolicited offers as warnings.
4. Never share bank credentials or OTPs.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Scholarship. Financial support for study, usually awarded on merit or need or both.

Grant. Non-repayable funding, often for a specific purpose.

Bursary. Award based primarily on financial need.

Eligibility criteria. The conditions an applicant must meet.

Personal statement. A written account of your motivation, experience and plans.

Referee. A person who provides a reference on your behalf.

Transcript. The official record of courses and grades.

CGPA. Cumulative grade point average.

Application tracker. A record of awards, deadlines, documents and status.

Award letter. The formal document confirming an award and its conditions.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - File

Documents.

- Scan and name all documents.
- Write a one-page CV.
- Identify two referees.

Week 2 - Search

Opportunities.

- Check department, faculty and state sources.
- List five awards with deadlines.
- Verify each against an official source.

Week 3 - Write

Statement.

- Draft 500 words with one specific anecdote.
- Adapt it to one award's criteria.
- Ask a lecturer for feedback.

Week 4 - Submit

Deadlines.

- Submit one complete application early.
- Confirm referees have received requests.
- Update the tracker.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Your university scholarship office guidance.
- A guide to writing personal statements for funding.
- Official websites of your state scholarship board and relevant foundations.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Name three credible sources of scholarship information.

Answer: The university scholarship office, federal or state scholarship boards, and verified corporate foundation websites.

2. What is a warning sign of a scholarship scam?

Answer: A request for an application or processing fee, especially through a personal account or unofficial link.

3. What should a personal statement avoid?

Answer: Generic quotations, vague claims about being hardworking, and text that could apply to any applicant or scholarship.

4. How should you request a reference?

Answer: Ask in advance, in person or by a clear message, provide your CV and the deadline, and follow up politely.

5. Why build a reusable document pack?

Answer: It reduces the time per application and prevents missing documents when a deadline is short.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write down five credible scholarship sources to monitor.
- [ ] Assemble your document pack in one folder.
- [ ] Draft a 600-word personal statement.
- [ ] Ask two referees and confirm their contact details.
- [ ] Prepare a one-page CV.
- [ ] Verify one opportunity through an official channel.
- [ ] Apply to at least one scheme this semester.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

> **More from the ZikShare Academic Vault**
> Find faculty primers, study-skills guides, money and career packs, and digital-skills workbooks in the ZikShare Library. New packs are added every semester.

ZikShare Academic Vault | Money & Career | 100L | 2026 Fresher Edition

YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

Scholarships, Grants and Financial Aid: Apply Without Wasting Money